



BHAICHUNG BHUTIA

Former India football captain



PERFECT OPPORTUNITY FOR INDIA TO **ENHANCE** CONTINENTAL RANKING AND REACH THE TOP 10

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This year is going to be a crucial one for Indian football. The AFC Asian Cup in Qatar marks the beginning of the action, followed by the FIFA World Cup qualifiers. If India can perform well in the Asian Cup and successfully progress through the stages of the 2026 World Cup qualifiers, it will augur well for Indian football's future.

I believe that with the World Cup qualification offering more spots to Asian countries, now is the perfect opportunity for India to enhance its continental ranking and reach the top 10 (currently ranked 18th in the continent). Achieving this target would not be very difficult, given the talent we possess.

It is a realistic goal to aim for, as it would increase our chances of qualifying for the main stage of the World Cup.

It is high time we knock on the door of qualification, and I am optimistic that we can make it happen by improving our performances.

It is not possible to finish in the top four or get into the decisive stage of the Asian Cup. But your performance in the tournament reflects where you stand in the continental assessment. All the top



Who next: It's high time Indian football starts searching for suitable replacements for Sunil Chhetri, says Bhaichung Bhutia. BISWARANJAN ROUT

footballers in Asia play it, as it is considered the biggest competition on the continent.

If you finish in the top eight, there is a high chance of qualifying for the World Cup.

Ever since we reached the final stage of the Asian Cup for the first time after a long break in 2011, we have been qualifying for the continental competition quite regularly. It is a positive sign for Indian football.

After having done it for almost 14 years, it is time to take it to the next level and qualify for the round of 16 or the quarterfinals. It is very important to reach the knock-out stages.

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Regarding the position of striker, I believe it's high time we start looking for players who have the potential to score consistently and demonstrate their worth to replace Sunil Chhetri. Since this could be his final Asian Cup appearance, we find ourselves in a situation where we must search for a replacement for Sunil. Therefore, we need strikers with the skills to perform consistently at crucial moments.